# ACM CODE OF ETHICS - Complete Guide with Examples

## 1. GENERAL ETHICAL PRINCIPLES (7 principles)

*Memory aid: "CHABHRF" - Contribute, Harm, Avoid, Be honest, Be fair, Honor, Respect*

### 1.1 Contribute to society and human well-being

- **What it means**: Use your computing skills to benefit people and society
- **Example**: Developing an app that helps elderly people access healthcare services, or creating educational software for underprivileged students
- **Remember**: "Computing for the greater good"

### 1.2 Avoid harm

- **What it means**: Don't create technology that hurts people physically, mentally, or socially
- **Example**: Refusing to build a surveillance system that violates human rights, or testing software thoroughly to prevent data loss
- **Remember**: "First, do no harm" (like doctors)

### 1.3 Be honest and trustworthy

- **What it means**: Tell the truth about your work, capabilities, and limitations
- **Example**: Admitting when you don't know something, being truthful about project deadlines, not exaggerating your software's capabilities
- **Remember**: "Truth in tech"

### 1.4 Be fair and take action not to discriminate

- **What it means**: Treat everyone equally; design inclusive systems
- **Example**: Creating AI algorithms that don't discriminate based on race, gender, or age; ensuring your website is accessible to people with disabilities
- **Remember**: "Tech for all, not some"

### 1.5 Respect the work required to produce new ideas

- **What it means**: Give credit to others' work; don't plagiarize or steal intellectual property
- **Example**: Citing open-source libraries you use, respecting software licenses, not copying someone else's code without permission
- **Remember**: "Credit where credit's due"

### 1.6 Respect privacy

- **What it means**: Protect people's personal information and data
- **Example**: Implementing strong encryption, not collecting unnecessary user data, following GDPR regulations
- **Remember**: "Your data is sacred"

### 1.7 Honor confidentiality

- **What it means**: Keep secrets; don't share confidential information
- **Example**: Not discussing client projects publicly, protecting trade secrets, respecting NDAs
- **Remember**: "What's private stays private"

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## 2. PROFESSIONAL RESPONSIBILITIES (9 principles)

*Memory aid: "SMARTER PC" - Strive, Maintain, Authorize, Take review, Evaluate, Respect rules, Perform competently, Public awareness, Computing resources*

### 2.1 Strive to achieve high quality

- **What it means**: Do excellent work in both process and final product
- **Example**: Writing clean, well-documented code; following best practices; thorough testing before deployment
- **Remember**: "Excellence is the standard"

### 2.2 Maintain high standards of professional competence

- **What it means**: Keep learning and stay ethical in your conduct
- **Example**: Taking courses to learn new technologies, attending workshops, staying updated with industry standards
- **Remember**: "Never stop learning"

### 2.3 Know and respect existing rules

- **What it means**: Follow laws, regulations, and organizational policies
- **Example**: Complying with copyright laws, following your company's security policies, respecting data protection regulations
- **Remember**: "Rules exist for a reason"

### 2.4 Accept and provide appropriate professional review

- **What it means**: Welcome feedback and give constructive criticism to others
- **Example**: Participating in code reviews, accepting peer feedback gracefully, reviewing colleagues' work thoughtfully
- **Remember**: "Feedback makes us better"

### 2.5 Give comprehensive evaluations of computer systems

- **What it means**: Fully assess systems including risks and impacts
- **Example**: Conducting thorough security audits, identifying potential vulnerabilities, assessing environmental impact of data centers
- **Remember**: "See the full picture"

### 2.6 Perform work only in areas of competence

- **What it means**: Don't take on projects beyond your expertise

- **Example**: Declining a cybersecurity project if you're a web developer without security training; knowing when to consult experts
- **Remember**: "Stay in your lane (or learn first)"

### 2.7 Foster public awareness and understanding

- **What it means**: Help non-technical people understand technology
- **Example**: Writing clear documentation, explaining technical concepts to clients in simple terms, promoting digital literacy
- **Remember**: "Bridge the knowledge gap"

### 2.8 Access computing resources only when authorized

- **What it means**: Don't hack or access systems without permission
- **Example**: Not accessing a colleague's account even if you know their password; only using company resources for work purposes
- **Remember**: "Permission required"

### 2.9 Design and implement secure systems

- **What it means**: Build systems that are both secure and user-friendly
- **Example**: Implementing two-factor authentication, designing intuitive security features, regular security updates
- **Remember**: "Security + Usability = Success"

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## 3. PROFESSIONAL LEADERSHIP PRINCIPLES (7 principles)

*Memory aid: "EAMES CR" - Ensure public good, Articulate social, Manage personnel, Articulate policies, Encourage growth, Special care, Recognize infrastructure*

### 3.1 Ensure that the public good is central

- **What it means**: Leaders must prioritize society's benefit
- **Example**: A tech lead rejecting a profitable project that harms user privacy; prioritizing accessibility features
- **Remember**: "Public good > profit"

### 3.2 Articulate, encourage, and evaluate social responsibilities

- **What it means**: Leaders must communicate and assess ethical obligations
- **Example**: Setting team goals that include social impact metrics, evaluating projects on their societal benefit
- **Remember**: "Lead with values"

### 3.3 Manage personnel and resources to enhance quality of working life

- **What it means**: Create a good work environment for your team

- **Example**: Preventing burnout, promoting work-life balance, providing growth opportunities, fair compensation
- **Remember**: "Happy team, better work"

### 3.4 Articulate, apply, and support policies that reflect the Code

- **What it means**: Leaders must create and enforce ethical policies
- **Example**: Establishing a company code of conduct, implementing ethical AI guidelines, creating whistleblower protections
- **Remember**: "Walk the ethical talk"

### 3.5 Create opportunities for professional growth

- **What it means**: Help team members develop their skills and careers
- **Example**: Providing training budgets, mentorship programs, conference attendance, challenging projects
- **Remember**: "Grow your people"

### 3.6 Use care when modifying or retiring systems

- **What it means**: Think about consequences when changing or discontinuing systems
- **Example**: Planning proper data migration before shutting down a system, notifying users well in advance, providing alternatives
- **Remember**: "Exit gracefully"

### 3.7 Recognize and take special care of critical infrastructure systems

- **What it means**: Extra caution with systems society depends on
- **Example**: Being extra careful with healthcare systems, power grid software, financial systems, emergency services
- **Remember**: "Lives may depend on it"

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## 4. COMPLIANCE WITH THE CODE (2 principles)

### 4.1 Uphold, promote, and respect the principles of the Code

- **What it means**: Follow the Code and encourage others to do so
- **Example**: Speaking up when you see unethical behavior, educating junior developers about ethics, being a role model
- **Remember**: "Be the example"

### 4.2 Treat violations as inconsistent with ACM membership

- **What it means**: Breaking the Code is serious and unacceptable
- **Example**: Reporting serious ethical violations, understanding that unethical behavior can end your professional standing
- **Remember**: "Ethics matter, consequences real"

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# SIMPLIFIED MEMORY FRAMEWORK

## The 4 Main Sections:

1. **GENERAL** (7) - Personal ethics basics
2. **PROFESSIONAL** (9) - How to work professionally
3. **LEADERSHIP** (7) - How to lead ethically
4. **COMPLIANCE** (2) - Follow and enforce the Code

## Quick Numbers to Remember:

- Total: **25 principles**
- Pattern: **7-9-7-2**
- Sections: **4**

## The Core Message:

*"Use computing skills to benefit society, avoid harm, be honest and fair, respect others, maintain quality, stay competent, and lead responsibly."*

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